non-Buddhists, and thus not really human and not worthy of pity. Their deaths were no stain on his eternal character.

The defence of the *sasana* is not always passive. It was the excuse used for the invasion of Arakan in 1784, since that kingdom was deemed to be insufficiently Buddhist[54] even though the Rakhine ethnic group represented a substantial Buddhist population. The presence of a large Muslim population was thought to put Buddhist traditions under constant threat. The irony here is worth noting. The invasion in 1784 was carried out in part as there were so many Muslims in Arakan. This contradicts the fantasy promoted by the regime and Buddhist extremists that there were very few Muslims in Arakan before the British conquest in 1826 and that the Rohingyas only arrived in the province in the colonial era.

However, by treating those of a different faith as not human in the ordinary moral sense, this doctrine lends itself very easily to mass violence against any other groups. As with many extremist movements, the underlying mindset is that almost any act can be justified by the final goal. In the case of the 969 Movement, the goal is to steadily increase the centrality of Buddhism to the governance of Myanmar. In this respect, this interpretation of Theravada Buddhism has something in common with extremist Islamic jihadist doctrines.[55] They too argue that it is essential for the state to only accept those with very particular beliefs and that the existence of those who dissent from their narrow doctrine is a threat to the entire political structure. In consequence it easy for jihadist movements to justify extreme violence,[56] as their end goal is, in their terms, morally just.

As Matthew Walton argues, ‘Buddhism and nationalism have become almost inseparably intertwined [in Myanmar].’[57] In this respect it is worth noting that Theravada Buddhism is followed by significant numbers of those in Myanmar who are not of Burman ethnicity and it is precisely this that makes it attractive to those seeking to find a common basis for citizenship in the country. If Myanmar cannot be reduced to just the ethnically Burman, then it might be possible to reduce it to just having a single religious belief-system: Buddhism offers the extremists a label that could unify all the citizens they wish to have in their nation. Furthermore, Islam is increasingly identified by the extremists as the religion that is particularly incompatible with their ideal political order, as they fear that the real goal of all Muslims is to displace Buddhism. This fear finds its expression in claims such as: ‘only small parts of Asia are Buddhist now; in